

physically imposing opponents.

While both the Netherlands and Japan had dominant qualifying runs, they will come up against a Sweden side that will thank its stars for having scraped into the 48-team tournament. Despite boasting two of the most prolific strikers of the current generation in its ranks — Viktor Gyökeres and Alexander Isak — the Swedes struggled in qualifying, recording zero wins in six games.

However, the team bounced back in the UEFA Nations League C during the 2024-25 campaign, which helped it secure a backdoor route through the playoffs. Under newly appointed manager Graham Potter, the Blue and Yellow then turned up at just the right time, with Gyökeres scoring four goals across two matches to book their place at the expense of Ukraine and Poland.

Tunisia completes the group after an outstanding qualifying campaign in which it recorded nine wins and a draw, and, more impressively, did not concede a single goal. However, history does not favour the Carthage Eagles, who have failed to advance from the group stage in their six previous attempts.



Viktor Gyökeres (Sweden)

While he may lack the flair and glamour of a modern-day attacker, Viktor Gyökeres has managed to hold his own thanks to his raw strength and instinct for finding the back of the net. He is in fine form heading into the World Cup, having finished as Arsenal's top scorer (14) as the club lifted the Premier League title after 22 years, and it may not be long before the mask celebration is brought out on the grandest stage.



Hannibal Mejbri (Tunisia)

The 23-year-old is the most recognisable name in the Tunisia squad, not just for his massive flowing afro but also his association with English giant Manchester United and, more recently, Championship-bound Burnley. Despite a disappointing season, Mejbri has the ability to switch between a playmaker on the ball and an aggressive presser off it, making him the crux of Tunisia's midfield.

SQUADS

Netherlands

Goalkeepers: Mark Flekken, Robin Roefs, Bart Verbruggen

Defenders: Nathan Aké, Denzel Dumfries, Jorrel Hato, Jurrien Timber, Jan Paul van Hecke, Virgil van Dijk, Micky van de Ven

Midfielders: Frenkie de Jong, Marten de Roon, Ryan Gravenberch, Teun Koopmeiners, Tijjani Reijnders, Guus Til, Quinten Timber, Mats Wieffer

Forwards: Brian Brobbey, Memphis Depay, Cody Gakpo, Justin Kluivert, Noa Lang, Donyell Malen, Crysencio Summerville, Wout Weghorst

Japan

Goalkeepers: Tomoki Hayakawa, Keisuke Osako, Zion Suzuki

Defenders: Ko Itakura, Hiroki Ito, Yuto Nagatomo, Ayumu Seko, Yukinari Sugawara, Junnosuke Suzuki, Shogo Taniguchi, Takehiro Tomiyasu, Tsuyoshi Watanabe

Midfielders: Ritsu Doan, Wataru Endo, Junya Ito, Daichi Kamada, Takefusa Kubo, Keito Nakamura, Kaishu Sano, Ao Tanaka

Forwards: Keisuke Goto, Daizen Maeda, Koki Ogawa, Kento Shiogai, Yuito Suzuki, Ayase Ueda

Sweden

Goalkeepers: Viktor Johansson, Kristoffer Nordfeldt, Jacob Zetterstrom

Defenders: Hjalmar Ekdal, Gustaf Lagerbielke, Gabriel Gudmundsson, Isak Hien, Victor Lindelof, Eric Smith, Carl Starfelt, Daniel Svensson, Herman Johnsson

Midfielders: Yasin Ayari, Lucas Bergvall, Jesper Karlstrom, Benjamin Nygren, Ken Sema, Elliot Stroud, Mattias Svanberg, Besfort Zeneli,

Forwards: Taha Ali, Alexander Bernhardsson, Anthony Elanga, Viktor Gyökeres, Alexander Isak, Gustaf Nilsson

Tunisia

Goalkeepers: Sabri Ben Hassan, Abdelmouhib Chamakh, Aymen Dahmene

Defenders: Ali Abdi, Mohamed Amine Ben Hamida, Adem Arous, Dylan Bronn, Raed Chikhaoui, Moutaz Neffati, Omar Rekik, Montassar Talbi, Yan Valery

Midfielders: Mortadha Ben Ouanes, Anis Ben Slimane, Ismael Gharbi, Rani Khedira, Hadj Mahmoud, Hannibal Mejbri, Ellyes Skhiri

Forwards: Elias Achouri, Khalil Ayari, Firas Chaouat, Rayan Elloumi, Hazem Mastouri, Elias Saad, Sebastian Tounekti